

Lessons of Leadership Past

Ulysses S. Grant

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OL 3020-91 Leadership Foundations

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February 5, 2026

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I currently reside in Fairborn Ohio while Ulysses S Grant stands as the most significant historical figure for my state. Grant was born in Point Pleasant Ohio and he later became the commanding general of the Union Army during the Civil War and he eventually became the 18th President of the United States. He stands as one of Ohio's most important historical figures because his actions protected the Union and his work developed Reconstruction. The research paper used George R. Goethals' 2008 scholarly article which reevaluates Grant's leadership abilities while disproving the negative image that historians created about him. The analysis of Grant through Northouse's leadership traits and styles demonstrates his greater effectiveness and his more intricate nature than common belief about him.

The leadership quality from Chapter 2 which most suits Grant demonstrates his unyielding determination. Northouse, P. G. (2020) defines determination through its components of sustained effort and strong motivation which enable people to continue their work during tough times. Grant demonstrated this aspect during the Civil War because he fought through all challenges. He maintained his commitment to his long-term strategy which he pursued until the end despite sustaining both significant losses and facing public backlash. Goethals (2008) describes Grant as having “courageous imperturbability,” meaning he remained calm and steady under extreme pressure. Grant demonstrated his determination to win during the Vicksburg campaign and his later battles against General Lee through his commitment to continue fighting despite experiencing initial failures. The Union achieved victory because of his persistent efforts. His determination shows itself through his intense focus on achieving the main objective instead of letting temporary challenges disturb him.

The second leadership quality which identifies Grant as an exceptional leader shows that he possesses integrity. Northouse P G 2020 defines integrity as the ability to display honest trustworthy behavior while maintaining consistent adherence to personal values. Historians consider Grant to be an honest man because his presidency faced numerous scandals yet he remained free from any charges of personal corruption Goethals 2008. He actively defended civil rights for all former slaves during Reconstruction because he believed in their right to equal treatment under the law. His strong belief in legal equality created a foundation for his principles. Grant demonstrated his true nature through his statement which he made during his Appomattox meeting with Robert E. Lee. Grant showed respect for moral principles when he judged former enemies on their ethical convictions. The combination of consistent behavior with dedicated behavior toward others demonstrates that leaders maintain their integrity throughout their service.

Grant demonstrates democratic leadership style because it represents his main leadership approach which Chapter 3 describes. Northouse, P. G. (2020) explains that democratic leaders involve others in decision-making, encourage participation, and value collaboration, while still taking responsibility for final decisions. Grant preferred to speak in a quiet manner because he did not possess dramatic or charming qualities. He maintained his composure while managing military operations through effective communication and coordination with his generals. Goethals (2008) notes that Grant did not match traditional expectations of a “charismatic” leader, yet he was highly effective because of his strategic thinking and steady presence. He extended his trust to Sherman who proved himself competent in executing their shared military strategy. He demonstrated democratic leadership by offering his team members the opportunity to provide feedback while working together to achieve common objectives. His leadership style maintained

a constant pace through his deliberate decision-making process which lacked any showy behavior.

The study of Grant demonstrates that leadership abilities do not depend on personal traits or physical characteristics. Goethals (2008) argues that Grant was often misunderstood because he did not fit common expectations of what a strong leader should look like. His life shows his dedication and uprightness and team-oriented approach when we analyze it through Northouse's leadership framework. As an Ohio resident I find it significant that a local leader from my state played a major role in leading the country through its toughest period. Grant demonstrates that his leadership created permanent results through his unwavering character and dedication to ethical principles.



Figure 1: The picture of Ulysses S. Grant

Source : [picture of ulysses s. grant - Search Images](#)

Reference:

Goethals, G. R. (2008). Imagining Ulysses S. Grant: Sifting through the shifting sands of conventional wisdom. *The Leadership Quarterly*, 19(4), 488-500.

Northouse, P. G. (2020). *Introduction to leadership: Concepts and practice*. Sage publications.